

CASE FILE - THE HANDWRITTEN DECEPTION

TITLE & TAGLINE

The Handwritten Deception

When every note tells a lie, the truth hides between the lines.

SYNOPSIS (One-line pitch)

At an exclusive alumni reunion held in an isolated farmhouse, event planner Riya is found dead in the library. A buoyant voice memo recorded minutes earlier contrasts with a staged suicide note and a tangle of physical and digital anomalies - forcing investigators into a spiral of ambiguity. The killer left logic-shaped clues but layered the scene so multiple plausible culprits remain. Teams interrogate five suspects and assemble evidence to determine what actually happened.

SETTING (for props & ambience)

- Private farmhouse, 40 km from the city. Main hall, library (where body is found), garden (with shed), driveway/front gate.
 - Three CCTV feeds (Front Gate = C1; Driveway = C2; Garden = G1). Cameras have minor unsynchronized clocks.
 - Event night: heavy storm with intermittent power flickers; generator kicks in at 02:20.
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VICTIM: Riya (29) - Realistic profile

- Owner of Lumen Events, hardworking, meticulous, emotionally disciplined but privately anxious.
 - Kept voice memos and hand-written journals. Recently discovered financial irregularities implicating a major silent investor. Planned to confront him privately at the reunion.
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PRINCIPAL CHARACTERS (with motives & flavor)

1. Srishanth - Investor (mid-30s). Charismatic, controlling, tied into Riya's company funds. Motive: avoid exposure & financial ruin. Public persona: generous; private: cold, strategic.
2. Vineet - Ex-boyfriend (early 30s). Hot-tempered, heartbroken, heavily intoxicated that night. Motive: messy breakup + jealousy + money quarrel.
3. Manvitha - Best friend (late 20s). Loyal, pragmatic, has access to Riya's journals. Motive: protect Riya's reputation & friends; may have moved evidence to protect someone.

4. Jeet - DJ/AV (early 30s). Low profile. Malfunctioning clock; unreliable timeline. Motive: none obvious-loyal, but witnessed odd interactions.
 5. Inspector Shreeya - Lead Investigator (mid-40s). Methodical. (This role can be either scripted AI-neutral narrator or a judging persona.)
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FULL TIMELINE (Production-ready, minute-by-minute)

Times are event timestamps (you will list camera timestamps and note which are later shown to be drifted).

- 22:00 Guests arrive. Toasts; Riya gives brief speech.
 - 23:10 Srishanth & Riya have a terse conversation by the bar; Manvitha sees them at a distance.
 - 00:05 Vineet gets into an argument, drinks heavily afterwards.
 - 00:45 Riya records a planning memo (process note) about accounts - non-urgent.
 - 01:20 Srishanth & Riya in library, hushed talk. Srishanth departs at ~01:40 (front camera).
 - 01:50 Riya records a fearful memo: "If anything happens, check Srishanth's payments." (VM_0150)
 - 02:00 Lighting flicker; generator hiccup later confirmed.
 - 02:05 Vineet accepts a drink offered by someone connected to Srishanth's circle.
 - 02:10 Camera C1 front gate shows Srishanth leaving (timestamp 02:10).
 - 02:12 Garden camera G1 shows a grey-blazer figure near library window (timestamp 02:15 on G1) - clocks later shown misaligned.
 - 02:14 Riya records short upbeat memo (VM_LAST_0214): "Hey Manvitha, I'm so happy tonight... I can finally breathe." (23s, ends with a faint rustle/thud)
 - 02:15–02:18 Power out; generator kicks in at ~02:20 (device logs). Cameras unsynced during outage.
 - 02:30 Jeet hears a muffled sound but trusts thunder.
 - 02:35 Manvitha finds Riya in the library beside an empty pill bottle and a handwritten note. Manvitha calls for help (02:36).
 - 02:42 Guests assemble; police called (02:42). First responders arrive ~02:57.
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EVIDENCE INVENTORY (production details: how to create each artifact)

I expanded to 14 artifacts so you have more toggles for misdirection. Under each I give a practical creation note (Canva/audio/photo) and its game function.

E1 - The Handwritten Note (Image)

- Text: “I’ve destroyed too many lives. I don’t deserve another sunrise. Forgive me. - Riya” (on cream stationery)
 - For production: Create in Canva with a cream paper background and a handwriting font that matches your “Riya handwriting” sample. Also produce a second “forged” version with slightly retraced strokes (use thicker stroke effect or overlay a traced path).
 - Function: Main “suicide” bait. Forensic analysis later will show inconsistent pressure and retraced strokes.
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E2 - VM_LAST_0214 (Audio + transcript)

- Contents: upbeat voice memo (female), 23s: “Hey Manvitha, I’m so happy tonight... I think I can finally breathe... Love you. Bye.” Followed by soft laugh, then faint rustle/thud (last 1s ambiguous).
 - Production: Record a calm female voice clip; add subtle thunder background and tiny muffled sound at end. Create a waveform image (Canva) and an auto-generated transcript screenshot.
 - Function: Emotional anchor and contradiction - suggests she was happy moments before death.
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E3 - VM_0150 (Audio/Text)

- Contents: fearful draft memo at 01:50: “If anything happens to me, check Srishanth’s payments.”
 - Production: Short audio or transcript screenshot. Label as VM_0150.
 - Function: Establishes Srishanth’s motive and Riya’s fear earlier in the night.
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E4 - The Pill Bottle (Photo + label)

- Item: Empty Dormax 25mg bottle, label and cap.
 - Production: Create a pill-bottle mockup in Canva with label text. Add a tiny “RX” style barcode. Photograph in soft light with pills spilled.
 - Function: Suggests sedative ingestion. Toxicology shows sublethal levels - ambiguous (could be administered or self-ingested earlier).
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E5 - CCTV Frame: Front Gate (Image)

- Production: Make low-res B/W still with timestamp overlay “02:10:23 – Cam_C1”. Show a silhouette of a man in dark jacket exiting. Slight motion blur; face not clear.
 - Function: Establishes Srishanth leaving at 02:10 (apparent alibi).
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E6 - CCTV Frame: Garden (Image)

- Production: B/W still with timestamp “02:15:12 – Garden_G1”. Show figure in grey blazer near library window. Simulate slightly different clock.
 - Function: Suggests re-entry / presence near library.
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E7 - Business Forms (PDF/Image)

- Production: Use Canva invoice / agreement templates; fill with fake transaction lines and sign with a handwriting font resembling Srishanth’s samples. Produce a multi-page PDF.
 - Function: Handwriting analyst links pressure rhythm to the note - a semi-forensic tie.
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E8 - Riya’s Phone Forensics (Image of Phone UI)

- Contents: Call log showing an attempted outgoing call to Srishanth at 02:11 (missed). Show a folder “Voice Memos” with VM_0150 and VM_LAST_0214.
 - Production: Canva phone UI mockup with timestamps. Label file retrieved from lawn.
 - Function: Shows she tried to call Srishanth after he was seen leaving - suggests she sought him out.
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E9 - Srishanth’s Shirt (Photo + assay note)

- Production: Photo of dress shirt with faint lipstick stain and a subtle red streak. Include a lab assay note: “trace hemoglobin detected; likely transfer.”
 - Function: Looks incriminating, but “transfer” ambiguity is key.
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E10 - Witness Log (Document)

- Production: Table with guests’ short statements and alcohol levels. Show entries for Manvitha, Vineet, Jeet, Guest A.
 - Function: Contradictory witness accounts; timestamp variances.
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E11 - Deleted/Partially Recovered Memo (Forensic screenshot)

- Contents: Fragmentary recovered audio transcript: “...he said he’d fix everything after tonight-” then cut.
 - Production: A “partly recovered” waveform image and transcript line. Create visual artifacts like “recovery timestamp” and “partial clip length: 3s”.
 - Function: Ambiguous - could be Riya being reassured or lied to.
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E12 - Anonymous Text (Screenshot)

- Contents: A message found on Riya's phone: "Don't go to the library alone. - Unknown" (timestamp 02:09)
 - Production: Phone UI screenshot. Could be from an unknown number.
 - Function: Suggests someone warned her - who and why? More confusion.
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E13 - Pen Cap (Physical photo)

- Item: Pen cap in garden shed; same model as pen used for the suicide note.
 - Production: Photo with scale ruler; label "Found near shed, 03:00."
 - Function: Suggests note written outdoors or moved; enables staged-scene theories.
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E14 - Glove Fragment (Fabric swab)

- Production: Small fabric piece with trace fibers; lab note suggests fibers consistent with grey blazer.
 - Function: Places blazer near library window - ties to E6, but ambiguous transfer.
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FORENSIC SUMMARIES (what investigators "report")

- Toxicology: Sedative traces (sublethal). Primary cause of death: asphyxia/neck trauma per autopsy.
 - Handwriting: Suicide note has retraced strokes and inconsistent pressure; pressure rhythm analysis finds a partial correlation with Srishanth's forms - not conclusive.
 - Digital forensics: VM_LAST_0214 intact on device; metadata consistent. Call log shows missed attempt to Srishanth at 02:11. Garden camera and front camera have small clock drift - later reconciled to place a figure at library window during power outage.
 - Acoustic: The final 1s of VM_LAST_0214 contains low-frequency thud; experts cannot conclusively call it a struggle.
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RED HERRINGS (how they mislead - use these actively)

1. Vineet's fingerprints on the pill bottle - looks like he administered it, but he was intoxicated and may have touched bottle earlier.
2. Manvitha handled the note - she discovered body and touched note, contaminating fingerprints.
3. Srishanth's shirt traces - transfer evidence could be benign (previous contact) or planted.
4. Anonymous text (E12) - implies a secret ally; could be Manvitha, a prankster, or a guilt-trip.

5. Pen cap found in garden - makes the scene look staged, but could be to throw off time-of-writing.
6. Partial recovered memo (E11) - ambiguous fragment that can be framed multiple ways.
7. Jeet's faulty clock - destroys a clean unified timeline.

Each red herring has a plausible innocent explanation, preventing quick consensus.

TWO-LAYER TWIST DESIGN (keeps teams divided)

- Layer 1 (Physical Truth): Srishanth physically assaulted Riya during generator outage and staged the scene to mimic suicide, then left the property to appear as if he had an alibi. He also tried to transfer incriminating marks to appear as if others were involved (shirt contact, small smears).
- Layer 2 (Complicating Actions After the Fact): In panic or to protect Riya's image, Manvitha moved or altered some things (e.g., picked up the note, placed the pill bottle near the body) believing she was preserving Riya's dignity or shielding someone. Simultaneously, Vineet's intoxication and the anonymous text create plausible scapegoats. This means multiple people touched evidence in ways that create multiple stories.

Result: any single piece of evidence supports at least two different narratives; only cross-correlation of many small indicators points cleanly to Srishanth.

Example unlock triggers (map)

- Ask Srishanth about "payments/transactions" → unlock E7 (Business forms).
- Ask Jeet about "clock/AV" → unlock E10 (Witness log) and note about clock drift.
- Ask Manvitha about "library/notes" → she may appear evasive; if prompted with "handwriting analysis" → unlock E1 (Note) + analyst short summary.
- Ask any suspect "Did you see Riya at 02:14?" → they may respond differently; repeated correct probing of contradictions unlocks E5/E6 CCTV stills.
- Keyword-driven clues: "phone call", "library window", "pill bottle", "garden shed", "pen cap", "deleted memo".

Design triggers conservatively so teams must ask probing questions, not just click to collect everything.

SAMPLE SUSPECT BEHAVIORS (for prompt templates)

You will implement suspects with system prompts directing tone and what they reveal.

- Srishanth (defensive, smooth): deflects, gives partial financial comments, avoids direct admission, hints at being framed. Occasionally gives small factual reveals if pressed with ledger evidence.
- Manvitha (emotive, protective): expresses sorrow, can be cagey about notes, may admit moving things to "protect dignity" under certain trust-building prompts.

- Vineet (angry, confused): slurs, admits blackout, mentions being given a strong drink; unreliable memory.
- Jeet (technical, blasé): focuses on AV facts; will confirm clock malfunction and generator hiccup if questioned technically.
- Inspector Shreeya (neutral): only answers about forensic summaries and official findings - useful as an objective anchor if you want one.

FINAL CANONICAL EXPLANATION (private scoring key - DO NOT RELEASE)

This is the official truth you use privately to score submissions:

- Culprit: Srishanth.
- Motive: He was diverting funds from Riya's company; Riya discovered records and threatened exposure.
- Sequence (simplified):
 1. Srishanth and Riya argued in the library around 01:20–01:40. Riya threatened exposure and recorded VM_0150 earlier naming him.
 2. Later in the night, during a power flicker, Srishanth confronted Riya again; an altercation ended with Srishanth applying lethal force (manual strangulation/asphyxia).
 3. Panicked, Srishanth attempted to stage the scene as suicide (the handwritten note) and briefly left the property to create an alibi (front gate footage at ~02:10). He re-entered near the library window (~02:15) to finalize staging.
 4. Manvitha, discovering the body moments later, moved or adjusted some items (pill bottle, note positioning) in a misguided attempt to "protect Riya's dignity" and perhaps to hide financial embarrassment-this inadvertently muddled fingerprints and chain-of-custody.
 5. Vineet was heavily intoxicated; he was not the killer but his fingerprints on the pill bottle and his blackout were used as red herrings.
 6. Srishanth's shirt contact and business form pressure-rhythm link provide the strongest circumstantial correlation; time drift between cameras corroborated by NTP reconciliation ties his presence near library at the crucial window.
- Killer's key mistakes (why canonical evidence supports Srishanth):
 - The handwriting pressure rhythm matches his business paperwork more than Riya's natural script.
 - He attempted to create alibi via leaving/re-entering during camera clock drift window.
 - Acoustic and camera cross-correlation places a figure near the library window at the time VM_LAST_0214 ends (the faint rustle) and power outages provide cover.

This yields high ambiguity, but when you weight multiple independent indicators (handwriting rhythm, audio timestamping, camera re-correlation, clothing transfer, and motive), Srishanth emerges as the most probable culprit.

PRODUCTION CHECKLIST (assets to make & deliver)

Visual/audio assets (create in Canva / Audacity / phone recordings / mockups):

- E1_note.png (2 versions: "as found" + "forged overlay")

- E2_VM_LAST_0214.mp3 + waveform.png + transcript.png
- E3_VM_0150.mp3 or transcript.png
- E4_PillBottle.png
- E5_C1_frame.png, E6_G1_frame.png (CCTV frames)
- E7_BusinessForms.pdf (2–3 pages)
- E8_PhoneUI.png (call log + voice memo folder)
- E9_SrishanthShirt.png & assay_report.pdf (mock)
- E10_WitnessLog.pdf
- E11_PartialMemo.png (recovery artifact)
- E12_AnonymousText.png
- E13_PenCap.png
- E14_GloveFragment.png & fiber_report.pdf
- CaseBoard_Corkboard.png (for projector)
- Admin answer key + scoring spreadsheet (template)